
THE FREE SEO GUIDE SERIES · 01

The Business Owner's Guide to On-Page SEO

How to improve your website's Google rankings, visibility and organic traffic
— without becoming an SEO expert.

Most businesses don't have a website problem. They have a visibility problem.

Your website can look excellent, load properly and describe your services accurately — and still send you almost no enquiries from Google.

That usually happens for one reason: the site was built to be looked at, not to be found. Design decisions were made carefully. Search decisions were never made at all.

It helps to know how Google actually works. Google does not rank businesses. It ranks **individual pages**. For one of your pages to be shown to someone searching, Google has to be able to work out four things from that page alone: **what you do, who you do it for, where you do it, and why your page deserves to be the answer** instead of the ten others competing for the same search.

On-page SEO is the work of making those four things obvious. It covers everything you control on your own website — the keywords you target, your page titles, meta descriptions, headings, content, images, internal links, URLs and local signals.

It is also the part of SEO with the best return for the least effort, because nobody is bidding against you for it. You either do it or you don't.

WHY THIS MATTERS

When someone searches for what you sell, they are not browsing — they are shopping. Search traffic converts because the intent already exists. You simply have to be there when it happens.

Everything in this guide is something you or your web person can action this week. No developer, no subscription, no technical background required.

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Understand search intent

Search intent is the reason behind the search — not the words in it. Get this wrong and everything downstream is wasted effort.

Every search falls into one of four broad categories. Each one needs a different type of page.

Informational — they want an answer

"why does my circuit breaker keep tripping" · This person wants to understand a problem. A blog article or guide wins here. They are not ready to hire yet, but they will remember who helped them.

Commercial — they are comparing

"best electrician in Manchester" · This person has decided to buy and is deciding from whom. Reviews, proof, credentials and clear pricing decide this one.

Transactional — they are ready now

"emergency electrician Manchester" · This is your most valuable traffic. It needs a service page that answers fast, proves you're available, and makes contact effortless.

Navigational — they want a specific business

"Acendia International" · They already know who they want. Your job is simply to be easy to find and to control what they see.

Why the wrong keyword produces traffic but no customers

A plumber who ranks first for *"how to unblock a drain yourself"* can win hundreds of visitors a month from people who, by definition, have decided not to hire a plumber. The same effort spent on *"blocked drain repair [city]"* would produce a fraction of the traffic and several times the revenue.

Volume is a vanity number. Intent is the revenue number.

SEO CHECK — 10 MINUTE EXERCISE

Open an incognito window and search your main service plus your city. Ignore the ads. Look at the first ten organic results and answer one question: **what type of page is Google rewarding?**

Service pages? Directory listings? The map pack? Blog articles? Google has already told you what it believes satisfies that search. If page one is all service pages, a blog post will not rank there — and vice versa. Match the format before you write a single word.

COMMON MISTAKE

Choosing a keyword because a tool showed high search volume, rather than because the people searching it are ready to buy. Ten searches a month from people about to hire beat a thousand from people doing homework.

SECTION 02

Optimise your page title

Your title tag is the clickable headline shown in search results and in the browser tab. It is one of the clearest signals you can send about what a page is about — and it is the first thing a searcher uses to decide whether to click you or your competitor.

How to write one:

- Lead with the primary keyword — put the important words first, not last.
- Include your location if you serve a specific area.
- Keep it to roughly 50–60 characters so it isn't truncated in results.
- Put your business name at the end, separated by a pipe or dash.
- Write it so a human would actually want to click it.

BAD Services | Company Name

BETTER Professional SEO Services for Small Businesses | Company Name

BAD SEO Services, SEO Company, Best SEO Agency, Cheap SEO | Company

BETTER Emergency Plumber in Bristol | 24/7 Callout | Hydro Plumbing

Repeating a keyword multiple times does not increase relevance — it reduces click-through and looks like spam to both Google and the person reading it. Say it once, clearly.

PRO TIP

Every page needs a **different** title. Duplicate titles across pages force Google to guess which page to rank for a search — and it frequently picks the wrong one. Check yours by searching `site:yourdomain.com` in Google and reading the list.

SECTION 03

Optimise your meta description

The meta description is the short summary beneath your title in search results — around 140–160 characters. It is **not a direct ranking factor**, but it heavily influences whether people click. A ranking that nobody clicks is worth nothing, which makes this one of the highest-leverage sentences on your website.

Include the keyword naturally, state what makes you the safe choice, and finish with a light call to action.

WEAK We are a plumbing company with many years of experience serving customers in the local area.

BETTER Burst pipe or blocked drain in Bristol? Licensed plumbers on call 24/7, with fixed-price quotes before we start. Call now for same-day service.

QUICK WIN

Google sometimes rewrites descriptions to match the search. Write them anyway — a well-written one is used most of the time, and a missing one is *always* replaced by whatever text Google happens to scrape off the page.

Build better page content

One page, one job. A single page trying to rank for five services usually ranks for none of them.

Give every service its own page — and, where you serve multiple areas, its own location page. This is the most common structural fix we make on small business websites, and often the one that moves the needle fastest.

Structure the page for how people read

- **One H1** that states the topic in plain language. Not a slogan — a description.
- **H2 and H3 subheadings** that break the page into the questions a buyer actually asks.
- **Short paragraphs.** Most of your visitors are reading on a phone, standing up, in a hurry.

Write helpful, not long

Word count is not a ranking factor. Completeness is. A 600-word page that fully answers the question outperforms a padded 2,000-word page every time.

Use the language a real customer and a real specialist would use around the topic. A roofing page will naturally mention flashing, guttering, tiles, leaks, inspections and warranties. That vocabulary is how search engines confirm the page has genuine depth — and you cannot fake it by repeating one keyword.

Demonstrate expertise with specifics

Generic claims — "quality workmanship, competitive prices, customer satisfaction" — are invisible, because every competitor makes them. Specifics are what convince a reader and differentiate a page: your process, materials, timelines, price ranges, licences and certifications, real photographs of your own work, named team members, genuine examples.

A PAGE FRAMEWORK THAT WORKS

H1 → the topic, stated plainly
Introduction → the problem in the customer's own words
Problem → what it costs them to leave it unresolved
Solution → how your service solves it
Benefits → the outcome, not the feature list
Process → what happens step by step once they contact you
Proof → reviews, results, credentials, photos
FAQs → the questions they ask on every phone call
CTA → one clear next step

COMMON MISTAKE

Copying the same service description across ten location pages and swapping only the city name. It is transparently thin, it rarely ranks in any competitive area, and it can hold back the pages around it. One genuinely local page beats ten duplicates.

SECTION 05

Images & media SEO

Images are the most common reason small business websites load slowly — and page speed affects both rankings and the far more expensive problem of visitors leaving before your page appears.

- **Descriptive filenames.** Search engines read them. Cameras do not name files helpfully.
- **Alt text.** Describe the image for someone who cannot see it. Include a keyword only where it is genuinely accurate. This is an accessibility requirement first and an SEO benefit second.
- **Compress and convert to WebP.** Typically 25–35% smaller than JPEG at the same visual quality.
- **Export at display size.** A 4,000px photo displayed in an 800px slot forces every visitor to download roughly five times more data than they need.

BAD IMG_4471.JPG · alt="image1" · 6.2 MB

BETTER emergency-plumber-bristol-burst-pipe-repair.webp
alt="Plumber repairing a burst copper pipe in a Bristol home" · 180 KB

QUICK WIN

The fastest performance improvement available on most websites is re-exporting the homepage hero and gallery images at the correct dimensions in WebP. No code, no plugin, often several seconds saved.

SECTION 06

Internal linking

Internal links are links from one page of your website to another. They help visitors move toward a decision, and they tell Google which pages exist, how they relate to each other, and which ones you consider important.

- Use **descriptive anchor text** — "commercial roof inspections", not "click here" or "read more".
- Link from supporting content to your money pages, not just outward from them.
- Every important page should be reachable within a few clicks of the homepage.



Done consistently, this creates a clear topical structure: a visible statement about which subjects your website covers in depth and which page should be the answer for each one.

PRO TIP

If no page on your site links to a page, you are telling Google it doesn't matter. These "orphan pages" are extremely common — and one of the easiest ranking problems to fix.

SECTION 07

URL structure

A URL should tell a person what the page contains before they click it. Clean URLs are easier to read, easier to share, easier to trust — and they reinforce what the page is about.

GOOD	/seo-services/	/local-seo/	/seo-for-law-firms/
POOR	/page?id=12345	/services123/	/new-page-final-v2/

Keep them short and lowercase, separate words with hyphens, and mirror your site structure. Leave out dates, version numbers and stray numbers entirely.

IMPORTANT

Do not rename URLs on an existing website without setting up 301 redirects. Changing a URL without one discards the ranking history you have already earned on that page.

SECTION 08

Local SEO fundamentals

If you serve a specific place, much of the battle is being unmistakably *of* that place — to customers and to Google.

- **Google Business Profile.** For "near me" and map results this often matters more than your website. Complete every field: primary and secondary categories, services, hours, service areas, photos, Q&A and posts.
- **NAP consistency.** Your business name, address and phone number should appear identically everywhere — website, Google Business Profile, directories, social profiles. Inconsistencies create doubt about which listing is correct.
- **Location relevance on the page.** Name the suburbs and regions you actually serve. Reference local landmarks and real projects naturally. Put your full address and an embedded map in the footer.
- **Service-area pages.** A genuine page for each key location, with content that could only have been written about that area.
- **Reviews.** A steady flow beats an occasional burst. Reply to all of them. Encourage customers to describe the service and the area in their own words.
- **Local schema.** LocalBusiness markup states your name, address, phone, hours and service area in a format search engines read directly rather than infer.

WORTH KNOWING

Local search gets competitive quickly. The fundamentals above put you in contention. The actual positions in the map pack are decided by proximity, prominence and relevance — which is why two businesses doing the same checklist can end up in very different places, and why the gap is rarely visible from your own website.

The on-page SEO checklist

Run this against one page at a time. Start with the five pages that matter most — usually your homepage and your top four service pages.

FOUNDATIONS

- ☐ Primary keyword identified
- ☐ Search intent understood
- ☐ One clear topic per page
- ☐ Page format matches what already ranks

ON-PAGE

- ☐ Title tag 50–60 characters, keyword first
- ☐ Location included where relevant
- ☐ Unique meta description with a CTA
- ☐ One clear H1
- ☐ Logical H2 / H3 structure
- ☐ Genuinely helpful, specific content
- ☐ Natural keyword and related terms
- ☐ No keyword stuffing
- ☐ FAQs answering real customer questions
- ☐ Proof: reviews, results, credentials

MEDIA & SPEED

- ☐ Descriptive image filenames
- ☐ Alt text on every meaningful image
- ☐ Images compressed / WebP
- ☐ Images exported at display size
- ☐ Page loads fast on mobile data

STRUCTURE

- ☐ Clean, descriptive URL
- ☐ Internal links pointing to this page
- ☐ Internal links pointing onward
- ☐ Descriptive anchor text
- ☐ No orphan pages
- ☐ Mobile-friendly layout

LOCAL SIGNALS

- ☐ NAP consistent everywhere
- ☐ Google Business Profile fully complete
- ☐ Service areas named naturally on page
- ☐ Dedicated service-area page where relevant
- ☐ Reviews being collected consistently
- ☐ LocalBusiness schema in place

CONVERSION

- ☐ One clear primary call to action
- ☐ CTA visible without scrolling
- ☐ Phone number visible on every page
- ☐ Contact form short and working
- ☐ Next step obvious on every page

HOW TO USE THIS CHECKLIST

Count the boxes you **cannot** tick. Ten or more unticked on a service page means that page is not genuinely competing for the search it was built for — it exists, but it is not in the race.

Work through your five most important pages before adding any new ones. Fixing what already exists is almost always faster and cheaper than publishing more.

DO THIS FIRST

Titles, meta descriptions, H1s and image compression. Highest impact, lowest effort, no developer required.

DO THIS NEXT

Content depth, internal linking and service-area pages. Slower to implement, but this is where compounding growth comes from.

What most businesses miss

You can apply everything in this guide — good titles, good headings, good content — and still not grow.

That is not a failure of the checklist. It is the limit of what can be seen from your own website. On-page optimisation is one layer of SEO. These are the layers underneath it, and they are where competitive markets are actually won or lost.

Technical SEO and crawlability

Pages that search engines cannot crawl, index or render properly do not compete at all. These issues are invisible from the front end — the page looks perfect to you.

Competitor gap analysis

You are not judged against best practice. You are judged against the specific businesses currently occupying page one for your searches.

Keyword and content gaps

The searches your buyers are already making that no page on your website currently addresses. Usually the largest single opportunity, and the hardest to spot from the inside.

Search intent mapping

Deciding which page should own which search, so your own pages stop competing against each other for the same term.

Internal link architecture

Where authority accumulates on your site and where it leaks away. Two sites with identical content can perform very differently because of this alone.

Schema and structured data

Telling search engines — and increasingly, AI answer engines — what you are in machine-readable terms rather than hoping they infer it.

Authority and backlinks

Whether your website has enough external credibility to rank for the terms you want, or whether you are targeting keywords that are currently out of reach.

Conversion paths

Traffic that does not convert is a cost, not a result. Rankings are the beginning of the job, not the end of it.

Your existing Search Console data

The keywords you already rank for in positions 5–20 are usually the fastest revenue available in SEO. Most business owners have never looked at them.

Prioritisation

An audit that produces forty findings is useless without impact-versus-effort ranking. The value is knowing which three to fix first.

"The biggest SEO opportunities are usually the ones you cannot see by looking at your website alone."

THE NEXT STEP

What is your website missing?

You now understand the fundamentals of on-page SEO. Knowing the fundamentals, though, is a different thing from knowing exactly what *your* website needs.

Every website sits in a different competitive market, with a different technical setup, different content, different local visibility and different conversion problems. Those differences are what determine your growth potential — and they are exactly what a professional audit exists to find.

YOUR FREE SEO AUDIT COVERS

- Where you currently appear in search — and where your competitors appear
- The technical and on-page issues holding your pages back
- Keyword and content opportunities you are not yet capturing
- Local visibility and Google Business Profile gaps
- A prioritised list of the highest-impact fixes, in order
- An honest answer on whether SEO is the right investment for your business right now

Fifteen minutes. No obligation, no pitch deck. We will not promise you a number one ranking — anyone who does is selling you something. What we will do is tell you what we would fix first, and why.

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